

A Thin Veiled Night
The Hills Above Allentown

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INT. DANI'S KITCHEN - FRIDAY MORNING

DANI'S MOTHER stands at the kitchen table with Dani's backpack open in front of her. She picks up a small SPANISH BIBLE, about the size of a paperback, blue vinyl cover, zipper around three sides like a pencil case. She opens it to the flyleaf.

In ballpoint, pressed hard enough to read from the other side of the paper: "Daniela Peña Almonte."

She zips the Bible into the front pocket of the backpack. Then she zips DANI PEÑA ALMONTE (12, seventh grade) into her coat up to the chin and pulls Dani's braid out from under the collar. Dani is wearing flat black school shoes. Once the Bible is in, the backpack hangs a little heavier on the left.

CUT TO:

EXT. SOUTH MOUNTAIN MIDDLE SCHOOL / FRONT STEPS - AFTERNOON

Last bell. Kids pour out onto Emaus Avenue. A CUSTODIAN works a push broom on the walk, herding a busted bag of Takis toward a dustpan. The wind keeps lifting the little red pieces and carrying them down the steps away from him.

ISAIAH WHITFIELD (13, eighth grade) already has his phone screwed into a little bendy-leg tripod from his birthday. He holds it up in front of him like a flashlight.

YADIEL ROSARIO (13, eighth, tallest by a head) wears his older brother's William Allen hoodie, canary on the front, sleeves past his fingers.

Dani stands with that backpack. Braid out over her coat collar.

BRYCE KRESSLEY (11, sixth, small for it) has a cracked leather binocular case around his neck on a strap. The binoculars inside are his grandmother's. Every fall she takes them up to Hawk Mountain for counting hawks, and she let him bring them today only if he is home by dark.

ISALIAH

Everybody keeps posting the lights. White lights over South Mountain, real low, no sound. Two hundred comments under every video, and it's aliens, it's ghosts, it's the end of the world.

He turns the phone so they can see the screen. Comment threads. Blurry white blobs.

ISALIAH (CONT'D)

It's drones. Or it's planes coming into the airport and the angle is weird. I'm going to get it clear, from close, and put it up, and that's the end of it.

YADIEL

From close how?

ISALIAH

From the pull-off. Right over top of where they come up.

YADIEL

My abuela says don't go up the mountain after dark.

ISALIAH

So we come down before dark.

DANI

Sunset is at six-thirty. We have three hours.

Bryce touches the binocular case like he is checking it is still there.

BRYCE

Grandma said twice. Home by dark.

ISALIAH

Then we go now.

They start up Emaus. The custodian loses another handful of Takis to the wind and keeps sweeping.

EXT. SIDE STREET CLIMBING SOUTH MOUNTAIN - CONTINUOUS

They pass the last houses. The sidewalk quits under their feet, and the pavement goes patchy. After that it is just gravel shoulder and trees.

Behind a yellow sign that says the road is not maintained in winter, a path starts up through the woods in a long zigzag. Dirt and roots, worn down by about a hundred years of kids.

EXT. SOUTH MOUNTAIN PATH - CONTINUOUS

It is warm for October. They are sweating inside ten minutes. The oaks are just starting to go brown, but the poplars have already dropped, and the leaves crunch and slide under their feet.

Isaiah talks most of the way up about how to shoot video clear, how to zoom in, and how a blurry clip can make people believe almost anything.

Dani's school shoes have no grip. She goes down on one knee in the leaves. Yadiel sticks his hand back without turning. She takes it. He pulls her up the steep part. Neither one mentions it.

Halfway up, off the path: a single roller skate on its back in the leaves. It is white, with pink laces, and all four wheels are missing. Bryce pokes it with his sneaker as he goes by. That is all anybody does about it.

BRYCE

What if it isn't drones.

ISAIAH

Then it's planes.

BRYCE

What if it isn't planes.

Isaiah halts on the path and braces both palms on his knees until he can catch his breath.

ISAIAH

My mom says people see what they need to see. She says that's what church is. People needed a story, so they got one. She quit going when I was eight.

YADIEL

My abuela says your mom is going to come back.

ISAIAH

Your abuela says that about everybody.

YADIEL

She's been right about a lot of everybody.

Yadiel goes on up ahead. That is the end of that.

EXT. SOUTH MOUNTAIN OVERLOOK - LATER

They come out of the trees onto the shoulder just above the pull-off a little after five. All four of them are breathing hard, faces flushed red.

A wide pull-off of gravel on the city side of the mountain. Room for maybe six cars. A steel guardrail at the edge. Nobody else is there. Fresh tire tracks swing around in the gravel. Wind moves the sumac below the rail. Way down, traffic.

The sumac has gone deep red like a stop sign, a thick tangle down into scrub oak and then the backs of the first houses. The sun drops left toward Trexlertown, flat and orange. Long shadows from every steeple and smokestack stretch across the rooftops.

Downtown, the PPL Building rises pale above the rest, its top already lit. East along Hamilton the streetlights blink on one after another. The Lehigh River cuts a dark line

through the middle. Off to the right, past where the hills fold, Bethlehem's old steel stacks glow in colored lights against the sky.

Down by the water a freight crawls along. At a crossing the horn gives two long pulls, the way a man leans his weight on it. The sound takes a second or two to climb up the mountain to them.

Isaiah wraps the tripod legs around a guardrail post until the phone sits steady. He aims it out over the sumac and starts recording.

The rail is cold under Dani's coat sleeve when she leans on it. On the post beside her someone painted J.R. + M.T. in silver a long time ago. Most of the M has flaked off.

They wait.

Behind the far ridge the sun sinks. Orange drains out of the rooftops into blue, and the streetlights start to matter.

Bryce keeps the binoculars up and calls what he sees.

BRYCE

Man walking a dog in a park. Bus.
Pigeon on a church.

Yadiel eats a bag of chips he has been saving since lunch and does not share them. Dani looks at him. He shares them.

EXT. SOUTH MOUNTAIN OVERLOOK - DUSK

Twenty minutes to seven.

Past the rail the hillside drops hard through red sumac and twisted little oaks. Allentown lies open under them, bright points scattered across the dark like a jar tipped over on a table.

Below them, the first light comes up out of the sumac.

It climbs out of the red bushes maybe a hundred feet downslope and hangs even with the scrub-oak tops. The kids look down on it, city lights behind. Below them. That is the first thing that is wrong about it. Everybody talked about lights up in the sky, and this one is close.

The light is white and about the size of a basketball. It does not blink once.

A second one rises beside it. Then a third. The three hang in a row at dusk and make no sound at all.

ISAIAH

Drones.

BRYCE

There's no buzz. There's no propellers. I can see the bushes right through the bottom of them. Isaiah, there's no anything holding them up.

Isaiah's phone keeps recording on the post. His face is lit white from the screen. He does not reach for it.

All four phones light up together. Dani's buzzes inside her coat. Yadiel's inside the hoodie. Bryce's back-pocket buzz is loud enough to make him jump.

Then Isaiah's phone speaker wakes up. Out comes the map lady's voice, calm and friendly and a touch slow, the same tone she uses when she says turn left in four hundred feet.

MAP LADY (ON PHONE)

Isaiah. You came to see us. Go ahead and ask.

Yadiel puts his hand on the back of Isaiah's hoodie and takes a fistful of it. Isaiah does not shake him off. He stands at the rail with his mouth a little open. Then he closes it. His jaw sets.

ISAIAH

How many cars on that train?

MAP LADY (ON PHONE)

Ninety-one.

ISAIAH

Bryce. Count it.

Bryce swings the binoculars to the river. His hands shake. He braces his elbows on the rail and counts out loud under his breath. The train is long. The back half is going behind buildings. Nobody moves.

He lets the binoculars drop. For a moment he holds the count to himself.

BRYCE

Ninety-one.

ISAIAH

What's my grandmother's middle name?

MAP LADY (ON PHONE)

Loretta.

Isaiah's fingers close hard on the guardrail top.

MAP LADY (ON PHONE) (CONT'D)

We were here before your city. We were here before the river had its name. We made the first of you, a long time ago, and then we went away, and now we have come back for the ones who can see. You can see, Isaiah. The others are not ready. Step over the rail and come down, and we will show you where you came from. You can bring your camera.

The three lights ease a little farther uphill. Under them the sumac stirs, red leaves flipping to show pale undersides, while the kids' faces feel no wind at all.

Isaiah lays a palm flat along the rail top. Next his left knee comes up onto the metal.

YADIEL

Isaiah. No, bro. No.

ISAIAH

They answered. They answered
everything. You heard them.

Isaiah swings a leg across. Beyond the rail sits maybe two feet of loose gravel, then sumac falling away with nowhere solid to step. His sneaker lands, skids, and he grabs the rail to catch himself.

Yadiel keeps a fistful of the hoodie. Bryce lets the binoculars thump against his chest, seizes Isaiah's belt from behind with both hands, and drops his weight into the gravel with his heels planted.

Dani unzips the front pocket of her backpack. Her fingers go stiff in the cold.

FLASHBACK TO:

INT. BEDROOM - SANTIAGO, DOMINICAN REPUBLIC - NIGHT (YEARS EARLIER)

Dani's mother sits on the edge of the bed. A fan runs in the window. Younger Dani listens from the pillow.

DANI'S MOTHER

If a voice comes to you and it is
not right, ask it about Jesus. Ask
it if He came in the flesh. If
they are from God they will tell
you yes. The others will not say
it.

BACK TO:

EXT. SOUTH MOUNTAIN OVERLOOK - DUSK

Dani draws out the small Spanish Bible and presses it shut against her coat with both hands.

DANI

Una pregunta.

Her voice comes out small. She makes it bigger.

DANI (CONT'D)
 ¿Jesucristo vino en carne? Sí o no.

Then again in English, slow and careful.

DANI (CONT'D)
 I have one question. Jesus Christ
 came in the body. Yes or no?

Isaiah's phone stays quiet on the post. The little red
 record dot is still blinking.

The three lights hang over the sumac. The leaves under them
 go still. Down below, the train blows for another crossing.
 The sound comes up the mountain and goes past them.

ISAIAH
 Answer her.

He is still stranded on the wrong side of the rail, one leg
 across, Bryce's full weight dragging on the back of his
 belt.

ISAIAH (CONT'D)
 You did the train. You did my
 grandma. Answer her. It's a yes or
 a no.

MAP LADY (ON PHONE)
 Isaiah. Come down.

ISAIAH
 Answer her question first.

MAP LADY (ON PHONE)
 Come down, Isaiah. The others are
 not ready.

Isaiah stands there a long time. The phone screen lights
 his face. He looks from the lights to the little blue Bible
 in Dani's hands and back again, the way he does when a
 science answer will not sit right.

Then Isaiah brings his leg back over to the safe side. His
 knee clips the tripod and spins it halfway around on the

post. Bryce topples backward into the gravel. Isaiah stands where he belongs, both hands locked on the rail.

The lights come up the hill.

They rush the hill together, ripping through sumac and scrub oak. The brush under them flails like a whole herd of deer tearing through.

Every phone buzzes and will not quit. From Isaiah's phone the map lady starts up again:

MAP LADY (ON PHONE)
Turn left. Turn left. Turn left.

It speeds up until the words smear into one sound.

Up close the lights are bigger. They have lost their round shape. None of the four will ever agree afterward on what shape they turned into.

Yadiel releases Isaiah's hoodie. He moves to the guardrail ahead of the other three and speaks the way his abuela spoke in the kitchen when grease caught fire in the pan: loud, flat, and sure.

YADIEL
En el nombre de Jesús. In the name
of Jesus. Get off this mountain.

The lights stop. So hard it is like they ran into the guardrail, about twenty feet down the slope. They hang there shaking.

Then they drop.

All three lights sink into the sumac like stones into a pond, then slide out under the bushes and flee. They skim low over the rooftops, cross Hamilton Street and the river, and go dark toward the airport until the four kids can no longer pick them out from any other light.

Every phone goes dead at once.

It goes quiet. Ordinary wind climbs back through the sumac. Down on the streets they can hear the traffic again.

Bryce discovers the binoculars are missing. The strap broke when he sat down hard, and only the empty leather case still hangs from its own strap around his neck. He pats the gravel where he was sitting. They aren't there. Up on his knees he peers over the rail and all he sees is the slope going down into the dark through the red bushes.

BRYCE

Those are my grandma's. Those are
for the hawks.

YADIEL

Nobody goes over that rail. Not
tonight. Not for anything.

Bryce stays on his knees a while longer, staring into the dark. At last he stands, brushes gravel off the seat of his jeans, and stays on this side of the rail.

EXT. SOUTH MOUNTAIN PATH - NIGHT

They take the path down in the dark. Halfway, Isaiah's phone wakes with four percent left. He switches on the flashlight and leads, arm stretched out ahead. Nobody talks the whole way.

Dani keeps the Bible in her hand the whole walk down. She never returns it to the pocket.

EXT. BOTTOM OF THE HILL / RESIDENTIAL STREET - NIGHT

At the bottom they step onto a residential street. On a porch a MAN stands on a stepladder working Christmas lights along the gutter in mid-October, hanging them or taking last year's down. He does not look down at them.

They pass under him without stopping.

INT. ISAIAH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Isaiah sits on the floor with his back against the bed. His phone is on the charger. Under the window the radiator ticks and knocks as it warms for the first time this fall.

On the phone: every video from that evening is gone except one. Eleven seconds.

He plays it.

On the screen his knee has clipped the tripod and spun the phone halfway on the post, so for those eleven seconds the lens looks back at the four of them instead of out over the city.

Isaiah's leg comes back over the guardrail. Bryce goes over backwards in the gravel. Yadiel lets go of the hoodie and steps up to the rail. Dani in her coat holds the little blue Bible up against her chest with both hands.

And behind Dani, on the pull-off gravel where no one had stood: a TALL SHAPE. It stands taller than any grown man by a good deal. Its back is to the camera. One of its hands rests on the guardrail beside her. It faces down the hill the same way she does.

Not one of the four saw it standing there.

Isaiah watches those eleven seconds again. And again. He does not post it. He never posts it.

The tall one never turns its face.

Isaiah sits with the phone in both hands and watches the shape that will not turn.

INT. DANI'S KITCHEN - MONDAY MORNING

Radio on the counter. Traffic on Route 22.

Dani's mother reaches for the blue Bible on the kitchen table, ready to zip it into the backpack's front pocket the same as Friday morning.

Before her mother can finish, Dani lifts it from her hands. She slides it into her own coat pocket on the right, where her fingers can find it.

Her mother lets her. From the doorway she watches Dani head down the steps toward Emaus Avenue, one hand in that pocket, thumb resting on the zipper.

FADE OUT.